

Primary Source Reading: The Final Argument, and the Death of Socrates

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Phaedo, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 10b: The Final Argument

Before you read: Cebes's objection still stands: even a soul that pre-exists the body and resembles the eternal Forms might simply wear out over time. Socrates now offers his most sophisticated argument, built around things that “always bring” a property with them — as fire always brings heat. Follow the logic carefully: it ends by showing not just that the soul is deathless, but that it cannot perish in any way at all. Then follow the argument to its consequence, in the room where Socrates actually dies.

What the Soul Always Brings

SOCRATES: Tell me, then, what is that of which the inherence will render the body alive?

CEBES: The soul.

SOCRATES: And is this always the case?

CEBES: Yes, of course.

SOCRATES: Then whatever the soul possesses, to that she comes bearing life?

CEBES: Yes, certainly.

SOCRATES: And is there any opposite to life?

CEBES: There is.

SOCRATES: And what is that?

CEBES: Death.

SOCRATES: Then the soul, as has been acknowledged, will never receive the opposite of what she brings... And what do we call the principle which does not admit of death?

CEBES: The immortal.

SOCRATES: And does the soul admit of death?

CEBES: No.

SOCRATES: Then the soul is immortal? (105c–e)

From Deathless to Imperishable

SOCRATES: And may we say that this has been proven?

CEBES: Yes, abundantly proven.

SOCRATES: Seeing then that the immortal is indestructible, must not the soul, if she is immortal, be also imperishable?

CEBES: Most certainly.

SOCRATES: Then when death attacks a man, the mortal portion of him may be supposed to die, but the immortal retires at the approach of death and is preserved safe and sound?

CEBES: True.

SOCRATES: Then, Cebes, beyond question, the soul is immortal and imperishable, and our souls will truly exist in another world!

CEBES: I am convinced, Socrates, and have nothing more to object. (105e–107a)

[The philosophical arguments are now complete. What follows, many weeks later in the dialogue, is the thing the arguments were about.]

The Cup

CRITO: Yet the sun is still upon the hill-tops, and I know that many a one has taken the draught late... do not hurry — there is time enough.

SOCRATES: Yes, Crito, and they of whom you speak are right in so acting, for they think that they will be gainers by the delay; but I am right in not following their example, for I do not think that I should gain anything by drinking the poison a little later. Please then to do as I say, and not to refuse me.

[Crito made a sign to the servant, who went out and returned with the jailer carrying the cup of poison. Socrates said:] You, my good friend, who are experienced in these matters, shall give me directions how I am to proceed. [The man answered that Socrates need only walk about until his legs grew heavy, and then lie down.] At the same time he handed the cup to Socrates, who in the easiest and gentlest manner, without the least fear or change of colour or feature... took the cup and said: What do you say about making a libation out of this cup to any god? May I, or not? ... I understand: but I may and must ask the gods to prosper my journey from this to the other world — even so — and so be it according to my prayer. Then raising the cup to his lips, quite readily and cheerfully he drank off the poison. (117a–c)

Last Words

And hitherto most of us had been able to control our sorrow; but now when we saw him drinking, and saw too that he had finished the draught, we could no longer forbear... Socrates alone retained his calmness: What is this strange outcry? he said. I sent away the women mainly in order that they might not misbehave in this way, for I have been told that a man should die in peace. Be quiet, then, and have patience.

[He walked about until his legs began to fail, then lay down. The numbness rose upward from his feet.] He was beginning to grow cold about the groin, when he uncovered his face, for he had covered himself up, and said — they were his last words — he said: Crito, I owe a cock to Asclepius; will you remember to pay the debt?

The debt shall be paid, said Crito; is there anything else? There was no answer to this question; but in a minute or two a movement was heard, and the attendants uncovered him; his eyes were set, and Crito closed his eyes and mouth.

Such was the end, Echebrates, of our friend; concerning whom I may truly say, that of all the men of his time whom I have known, he was the wisest and justest and best.
(117d–118a)

After you read: Notice what Phaedo says at the very end — not that Socrates proved his argument, but that he was the wisest and justest and best man Phaedo had known. The dialogue closes on a person, not a conclusion. As the lesson discusses, this is not an accident: Plato wants the reader to see the argument and the death together, so that the composure in the cell becomes part of the case for what philosophy is for.